



Partly sunny 81/56 • Tomorrow: Party sunny 81/65 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, APRIL 24, 2025 • \$4

Zelensky defiant as U.S. twists his arm

White House threatens to walk away if he refuses to agree to concessions

BY SIOBHÁN O’GRADY, STEVE HENDRIX AND ADAM TAYLOR

KYIV — President Donald Trump and Vice President JD Vance insisted Wednesday that Ukraine needed to make concessions to ensure peace, prompting Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky to push back and demand that Russia must accept a full ceasefire before negotiations.

Trump accused Zelensky on Wednesday of “boasting” after the Ukrainian leader told reporters the day before that Kyiv will never recognize Crimea as Russian territory. “He can have Peace or, he can fight for another three years before losing the whole Country,” Trump wrote on Truth Social. “We are very close to a Deal, but the man with ‘no cards to play’ should now, finally, GET IT DONE.”

Trump’s post came shortly after Vance warned that the White House could walk away from its own peace deal if progress is not made soon.

Zelensky responded in a late-evening message that there were “many emotions” throughout the day but said that Ukraine was grateful for its partners. The Ukrainian leader added that he hoped the United States would comply with its past decisions, sharing a link to the declaration made by the first Trump administration that refused to recognize Russian sovereignty of Crimea.

The 2018 declaration, made by then-Secretary of State Mike SEE UKRAINE ON A11

Russia: U.S. rolls back initiatives to investigate war crimes. A11



PHOTOS BY MELINA MARA/THE WASHINGTON POST

‘We’re just hearing nothing’

L.A. usually brims with wildlife. But January’s fires upended their natural habitats.

BY REIS THEBAULT

SANTA MONICA MOUNTAINS, CALIF. — Tuna Canyon was too quiet. The rugged gorge on the edge of Los Angeles, overlooking the twinkling Pacific Ocean, would normally be buzzing with the sounds of life: birdsong from the bushes, the patter of paws on the hillside, the splash of newts in the stream below.

That was before the mountains burned. The January firestorms across this Southern California county torched entire neighborhoods and displaced thousands of people. But the disaster also tore through the natural world, disrupting fragile ecosystems that — despite popular imagination — define Los Angeles just as much as its freeways and strip malls.

Roughly three months after the fires broke out, SEE WILDFIRE ON A7



FROM TOP: Researcher Seth Riley walks through the Santa Ynez Canyon in California. A tree frog sits in the muddy silt along a creek in the area.

Trump softens tone on tariffs

HE PREDICTS MAKING A DEAL WITH CHINA

But levies will not be cut soon, White House says

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

President Donald Trump, stung by a mounting backlash to his historic tariff plans, signaled on Wednesday that he is aiming for an end to the most intense period of global trade conflict in several decades.

The president talked for weeks about the need for Americans to endure short-term pain before enjoying his promised “Golden Age” of manufacturing-heavy prosperity. But with financial markets rocking and business leaders warning of product shortages, Trump now is highlighting his expectations for reaching a “fair deal” with China — and his aides are touting prospects for other early agreements.

Coupled with conciliatory remarks about Federal Reserve Chair Jerome H. Powell, Trump’s upbeat trade talk was enough to spur a Wall Street rally. Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent’s public endorsement of a continued U.S. role in the International Monetary Fund and World Bank, though conditioned on institutional changes, added to the improved mood.

On Wall Street, investors welcomed the apparent change of heart, sending the S&P 500 index up nearly 3.5 percent in early trading before it closed with a 1.7 percent gain. So far this year, stocks are down more than 8 percent, as SEE CHINA ON A14

A reversal: Aides counseled Trump against attacking Fed chair. A6

Durbin won’t run, opening a top spot for Democrats

BY THEODORIC MEYER AND HANNAH KNOWLES

Sen. Dick Durbin of Illinois said Wednesday that he won’t run for reelection next year, opening up the No. 2 slot in Senate Democratic leadership for the first time in two decades.

Durbin, 80, was first elected to the Senate in 1996 and has served as the Democratic whip since 2005. He is also the top Democrat on the Senate Judiciary Committee.

His departure is a part of a coming generational shift in the chamber, where the median age is about 65. Durbin is the fifth senator to announce that he will not run for reelection, along with Sens. Mitch McConnell (R-Kentucky), 83; Gary Peters (D-Michigan), 66; Tina Smith (D-Minnesota), 67; and Jeanne Shaheen (D-New Hampshire), 78.

Durbin’s decision gives Democrats another seat to defend in next year’s midterm elections — but it also spares the party the prospect of an older senator running for reelection as many Democrats clamor for younger faces.

It opens up a rare Senate seat in a deep-blue state that has not SEE DURBIN ON A5

Heat is bleaching world’s coral reefs at record scale

BY LEO SANDS AND AMUDALAT AJASA

Coral reefs around the world are losing their color at an unprecedented scale as a result of rising sea temperatures, federal marine scientists announced this week, with 84 percent of reefs exposed to bleaching levels of heat since 2023.

The massive blow to marine

habitats reported by the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration — the highest share ever recorded — comes as the planet experiences its fourth global coral bleaching event, which occurs when bleaching is confirmed in all of the oceans’ basins at once. It raises new concerns about the precarious nature of a living network that sustains vibrant fisheries worldwide and helps

protect coastal communities from flooding.

NOAA says the latest global event began on Jan. 1, 2023, and mass bleaching has now been observed across at least 83 countries and territories, threatening marine life from Fiji to the Florida Keys to Australia’s Great Barrier Reef.

“The ongoing global coral bleaching event is the biggest to

date,” NOAA scientists said.

Bleaching occurs when heat upends the coral’s metabolism, causing it to turn white as it expels the symbiotic algae that provide it with nutrients and color. Bleaching doesn’t mean the coral has died, but prolonged bleaching — which scientists say is made more frequent and severe by rising sea temperatures — can kill it.

SEE CORAL ON A9



DAR YASIN/AP

Risky crossroad for nuclear-armed foes

A family member is overcome by grief

Wednesday during the funeral procession of an Indian man gunned down Tuesday when militants launched an ambush in Indian-controlled Kashmir. A fragile ceasefire between India and Pakistan, both of which claim the region and administer separate parts of it, is at risk after the indiscriminate attack on a crowd of mostly tourists, the deadliest on civilians in India in more than a decade.

Story, A10

Hegseth had Signal app installed on office desktop

BY DAN LAMOTHE

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth directed the installation of Signal, a commercially available messaging app, on a desktop computer in his Pentagon office, said three people familiar with the matter, illustrating the extent to which he has integrated use of the unclassified communications platform at the center of his political troubles with the highly secure systems the U.S. government relies on to safeguard military plans and other sensitive information.

In doing so, Hegseth effectively “cloned” the Signal app on his personal cellphone, these people said, speaking on the condition of anonymity to discuss an issue that has hounded the Trump administration for weeks. The move followed a discussion among Hegseth and his aides about how they could circumvent the lack of cellphone service in much of the Pentagon and more quickly coordinate with the White House and other top Trump officials using the encrypted app, they added.

SEE HEGSETH ON A4

100 days at helm: Pentagon chief touts his record, lays into critics. A4

IN THE NEWS

Held by ICE, revered in Vermont Mohsen Mahdawi, a U.S. permanent resident and Columbia University student, has a deep well of support in a community he calls home. A3

Get your kazoo, D.C. In the nation’s “loneliest city,” sing-alongs bring strangers together for some melodic merriment. B1

THE NATION The VA secretary, echoing a Trump order, is asking staff to report anti-Christian bias. A3 A federal judge pressed the White House on its efforts against law firms. A4

THE WORLD Tens of thousands of people lined up to bid farewell to Pope Francis on Wednesday, as the Roman Catholic Church began three days of viewings of the late pontiff as he lies in state. A12

THE ECONOMY ChatGPT maker OpenAI’s plan to shed its nonprofit status so it can more easily make money from AI faces growing opposition. A13 Thrifting apps are seeing a rush of interest as tariffs on China threaten to raise prices of clothing. A14

THE REGION Prison terms arrived this month for the last of 17 members of a gang that officials say was one of the most violent and sophisticated in D.C. B1 A teenage boy was injured in a stabbing during a fight at a Fairfax County high school, local authorities said. B1

STYLE Harvey Weinstein returned to court for retrial on sex crime charges after his conviction was tossed on appeal. C1

LOCAL LIVING A California couple eliminated fossil fuels in their home, but savings from going green have thus far been elusive.

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